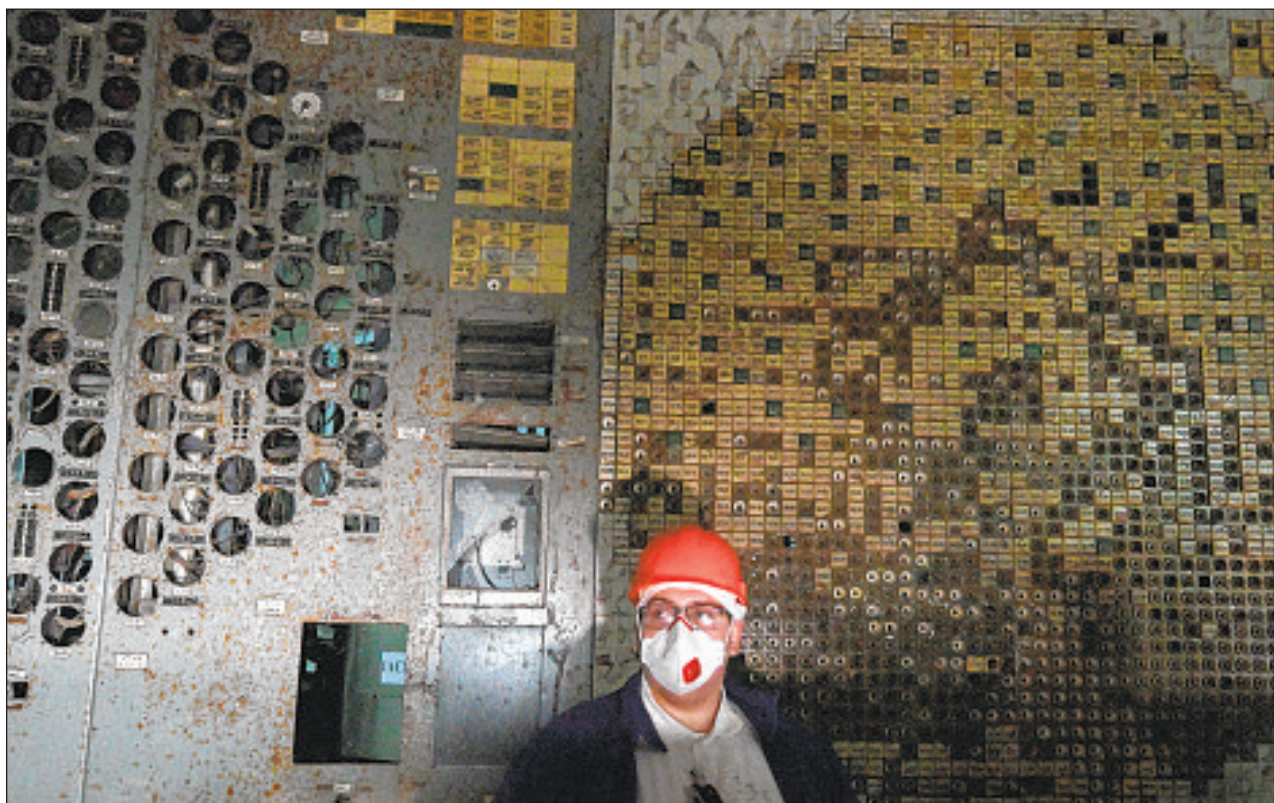




SERGEI SUPINSKY AFP/Getty Images

CHERNOBYL, 40 YEARS LATER

An employee of the Chernobyl nuclear plant walks in the control room of the damaged Reactor No. 4. Ukraine will mark the anniversary of the disaster at a time when war is a threat to the plant. **WORLD, A4**

Voter ID measure qualifies for state ballot

If California passes it, identification would be required, aligning with a GOP-led drive.

By JENNY JARVIE AND DAKOTA SMITH

SACRAMENTO — California voters will have the opportunity in November to weigh in on a contentious ballot measure pushed by Republicans that would require all voters in future elections to show identification every time they vote in person or provide a special PIN when submitting mail-in ballots.

Supporters of the measure, which elections officials announced Friday had qualified for the Nov. 3 ballot, claim it would also require election officials to verify registered voters are U.S. citizens — a move that aligns with a GOP-led drive for new restrictions on voters in the wake of President Trump's baseless claims that the 2020 election was stolen and that undocumented immigrants are swaying elections by voting illegally.

Republican Assembly member Carl DeMaio from San Diego and other proponents of the California voter ID initiative have been pushing for voter reform for several years, while Trump and Republicans also seek a similar initiative at the federal level. In March, DeMaio and his political advocacy group, Reform California, sub

[See **Voter ID**, A10]

Depleted national parks brace for summer surge

Multitasking staffers fear a push for more cuts could further undermine operations.

By JUSTINE MCDANIEL

WASHINGTON — When families flocked to Yosemite National Park during their recent spring breaks, some met two-hour waits at the entrance gates. At a lakeside spot in the North Cascades in Washington state, there hasn't been enough staff to open the visitors center. And in Death Valley, water was shut off at two campgrounds.

National parks staff and



BRONTE WITTPENN San Francisco Chronicle

THE WELCOME Center at Yosemite National Park, which eliminated its timed-entry reservation system.

advocates fear that such issues could only worsen this summer, as the park system faces the busy season with a dramatically reduced staff. At Yosemite, concerns are compounded by the National Park Service's recent elimination of the park's timed-entry reservation system, which led to the long spring-break lines.

"We're definitely really nervous and anxious about the upcoming season, especially with the staff shortage we already have," said a National Federation of Federal Employees union member at Yosemite who requested anonymity to speak candidly.

The National Park Service [See **Parks**, A11]

COLUMN ONE

Working with 'El Chapo' — then betraying him

The Flores twins of Chicago were born into drug trafficking and thrived before turning informants

By Kate Linthicum

To build their billion-dollar drug empire, the Flores brothers worked together as a perfect machine. Identical twins born in Chicago to Mexican immigrant parents, they could communicate without speaking — just a raised eyebrow or grunt would do.

Pedro, who went by Pete, had the smarts and discipline to manage a sprawling binational business. Margarito, known as Jay, brought the charm and deal-making savvy.

By their early 20s, they were doing business with the world's most powerful drug lords, including Sinaloa cartel chief

Joaquín "El Chapo" Guzmán.

The twins were born into the drug trade and had grown up on gangster flicks such as "Scarface," but several brushes with death convinced them they didn't want to end up like the film's protagonist, Tony Montana, a cocaine smuggler killed in a hail of gunfire.

So they made a dramatic choice that put a target on their backs forever:

They snitched.

Their spying helped bring down El Chapo and marked the starting point of a trend of high-profile drug lords cooperating with federal authorities that continues to this day. But it came with a price — the

[See **Twins**, A6]

LAFD's culture of obedience

Fearing retaliation, firefighters silent even on dangers

By ALENE TCHEKMEDYAN

As firefighter after firefighter testified about their actions during the Lachman fire, a clear theme emerged: the Los Angeles Fire Department's culture of absolute obedience.

One told a boss about red hot coals and smoldering ash. Another warned that warm weather increased the risk of a flareup. After taking their concerns to superiors, they gave up — it was not their job to make decisions like when to pack up their hoses and leave a fire that had mostly been put out.

Days later, that fire

reignited into the Palisades fire, destroying thousands of homes and leaving a dozen people dead.

"I could've possibly prevented a lot of stuff if I would've been more outspoken, right?" firefighter Scott Pike testified in a lawsuit brought by Palisades fire victims. "But that's not the right thing to do. The captains don't want to hear that."

Pike's attitude reflects deep-rooted norms within the LAFD not to question orders — or to push back against higher-ups when something feels wrong, or even dangerous — because doing so could invite retribution. Several current and for-

mer firefighters told The Times that it's often easier to keep their mouths shut than deal with the ramifications of speaking up.

Similar to law enforcement, fire departments are paramilitary organizations handling fast-moving, life-and-death emergencies where there's often no time for debate.

What's more, firefighters typically work 24-hour shifts and live with their crew at the station, cooking, eating, sleeping and exercising together. Being ostracized isn't just losing the camaraderie of co-workers — it's losing a family.

The culture of silence [See **LAFD**, A11]

Legal strategy used by Edison shields fire data

Documents on cause of deadly Eaton blaze are kept secret, just as with earlier disasters.

By MELODY PETERSEN

After last year's disastrous Eaton fire, Southern California Edison executives vowed to be transparent about what caused the inferno that killed at least 19 people and left thousands of families homeless in Altadena.

"As we better understand exactly what happened on Jan. 7, we do so with a commitment to remain transparent," Pedro Pizarro, chief executive of Edison International, the utility's parent company, said in a published statement after the fire.

In court, however, Edison is keeping crucial documents of the cause of the Eaton fire secret, a legal strategy it has used to shield what happened in at least seven earlier wildfires it was blamed for igniting, according to a Times review.

Edison's stance has caused mounting frustration with attorneys representing fire victims who are seeking compensation for their losses.

"The Eaton Fire cases should be decided on their merits, not on what information that SCE has been able to withhold," lawyers for the victims wrote in a recent court filing.

State regulators have repeatedly criticized Edison for its secrecy in previous fires, saying it violated safety regulations and stopped officials from learning the root cause so that similar disasters could be prevented.

For more than a year, Edison employees have been gathering detailed information about what ignited the fire in an investigation the company is required to perform under state utility regulations.

But most of that information is being withheld by Edison's claim of attorney-client privilege, as well as a protective order that it asked a judge to approve soon after the fire.

[See **Edison**, A16]



AARON SCHWARTZ Bloomberg

PEDRO PIZARRO, CEO of Edison, says, "We still, to this day, don't fully understand what happened."

D.C. scandals spur a push for reforms

Lawmakers wonder if rules for self-oversight can keep pace with ongoing misconduct.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — In the span of 10 days, the nation's capital saw a cascade of ethics scandals that cut across party lines and branches of government, raising fresh doubts about whether Washington is capable of holding itself accountable.

Three members of Congress — two Democrats and a Republican — resigned within days of one another as they faced calls for their expulsion due to their alleged misconduct. A fourth lawmaker is facing the same pressure but has so far refused to step down.

A Cabinet secretary stepped down amid a months-long investigation into allegations that she pursued a romantic relationship with a member of her security detail, while her husband stood accused of

sexually assaulting female staffers in her agency.

In a separate case, the Department of Homeland Security confirmed last week that it put a senior counterterrorism official on administrative leave as it investigates an ex-boyfriend's allegations that she was seeking out wealthy men online to pay for luxury items.

The back-to-back resignations and investigations, spanning both parties and both the legislative and executive branches, have reignited a debate about whether Washington's rules and institutions for self-oversight can keep pace with the misconduct unfolding within it. Even those charged with policing it say the system is failing.

"Clearly, we have an ethical problem," Rep. Mark DeSaulnier (D-Concord), the top Democrat on the House Ethics Committee, said in an interview.

DeSaulnier, who has served on the committee since 2023, said the panel is long overdue for an overhaul. He would like to see the

[See **Misconduct**, A10]

Make a right choice for hospice care

Fraud is rampant, but good options exist. Navigate the journey with Steve Lopez's help. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Lakers believe, and so should we

Team is a legitimate title contender after a "gutty win," writes Bill Plaschke. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather
A morning shower.
L.A. Basin: 69/53. **B8**

Opinion Voices A18
Obituaries B4

Climb aboard, then go explore

As Metro's D Line extension adds three new stations, a look at things to do. **WEEKEND, L6**

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